

Console Curry

From “complete home entertainment systems” to amusement devices, gaming consoles are going at it like never before



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Perhaps we're living in one of those Golden Ages they keep talking about. Over two short years, we've witnessed the launches of three high-profile consoles, each of which promises to change the world of gaming forever. The Xbox 360 has its cult online following, the PlayStation 3 has its horrifyingly advanced hardware, and the Wii has fun on its side... which one's going to outlast the rest?

Does it even matter? For our opinion on the subject, pick up last month's issue and flip to *Ultimate Gaming Champion*. The Wii will usher in a whole new era of innovation, but might take a hit with people looking for high definition graphics and sound. Overall, we should see around four or five years of the current next-gen consoles before it occurs to someone to kill the competition with the generation beyond that.

And Then...

It almost hurts the brain to try and conceive of a console beyond what we already have—both the Xbox 360 and PS3 are formidable machines that are still to show their full potential—but (now former) Sony CEO Ken Kutaragi has already cooked up plans for the PlayStations 4, 5 and 6, though he's not telling anyone what those plans are.

As early as 2004, Sony researchers had built a vision for the console of the future. Controllers and button-mashing will become a thing of the past—your console will watch your body's movements, facial expressions and even listen to your

voice to interpret special voice commands. The head-mounted display idea rears its head here, too, and games will be beamed right to our retinas. Who knows, the console itself may mobile—your own little R2D2, which will follow you around your house, and hopefully save you from jumping off your balcony when you get too lost in your display.

There will be all-pervasive wireless broadband, and maybe you'll play your game on a “virtual console” that exists only online—so you can wander around with your head-mounted display and play your game from anywhere.

Feet On The Ground

Dreams spewed by research groups are all very well, but we want more concrete information, don't we? We do know that the Xbox 360's successor is under development already—Microsoft EMEA Vice President Chris Lewis told UK games site Kiziko, “You can't sit back on your laurels in this business—the consumer won't let you, the developers certainly won't let us.” They've even formed a computer architecture group, which will be working on some heavily customised hardware, if not designing the hardware itself. Microsoft's patent application suggests that the next Xbox (the neXtBox?) will act as a single hub, which will also interact with your Zune, Windows Mobile device and any other Microsoft gadget that it finds in its vicinity.

News from the Sony camp is that we might see a PlayStation 4 as early as 2010! The new console will feature similar gaming hardware, but will be more tuned towards eliminating the